



FLYING HIGH

A Pacific Northern Airlines Douglas DC-3 soars over the mountains of Alaska. The runaway success of the DC-3 made Douglas the world's leading manufacturer of civil aircraft – a lead that it maintained until the advent of the Boeing 707 in the late 1950s.

passengers seated would achieve the holy grail of commercial aviation – a profit on passenger operations alone. Smith persuaded Douglas to build a bigger version of the DC-2 to meet this specification. The result, the Douglas Sleeper Transport (DST), entered service in December 1935 and became one of the most successful airplanes in aviation history in its better-known “day coach” version, the DC-3.

With the advent of the DC-3, air travel had come of age. Progress in instrument-flying and radio navigation meant that emergency landings and canceled flights had become uncommon, while night flying was a standard feature of airline schedules. Around-the-clock operations with an airplane carrying 21 passengers generated a profit despite falling ticket prices, which of course encouraged more people to fly. By the end of the 1930s, US airlines were carrying three million passengers a year, 90 percent of them traveling in DC-2s or DC-3s.

DONALD DOUGLAS

BORN IN BROOKLYN, NEW YORK, Donald Douglas (1892–1981) spent two years at the US Naval Academy before switching to study aeronautic engineering at MIT, completing the four-year course in two years. In 1915, at the age of 23, he was taken on by the Martin company as chief engineer, helping to design America's first two-engined bomber, the MB-1. In 1920, Douglas moved to California hoping to set up his own aircraft company. He worked out of an office in a barber's shop until rich sportsman David Davis gave him \$40,000 to build an airplane that could fly nonstop coast-to-coast. The aircraft Douglas produced, the Cloudster, never made it across the continent, and Davis later drifted away from aviation, but the Douglas Company was firmly established. It began making torpedo planes for the US Navy, and when four of these were adapted as Douglas World Cruisers for the first

global circumnavigation flight in 1924, the company's reputation was made. By 1928, the Douglas Company was worth \$28 million and employed the best designers Douglas could find. During the 1930s it created some of the world's finest piston-engined aircraft, including the DC-1, DC-2, and DC-3, one of the most successful aircraft ever built.

SCOTS PATRIARCH

Of Scottish ancestry, with a fondness for Robbie Burns, Douglas ran his company in a distinct patriarchal style. He remained in control well past retirement age, until financial difficulties forced him to sell to McDonnell in 1967.

